SPEECH ARTS

Speaking Nigerian English on Stage

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

Accent, intelligibility and identity: how Nigerian actors handle standard and localised English, pidgin, code-switching and verse, without flattening either the language or the character.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- standard Nigerian English
- accent
- pidgin
- code-switching
- verse speaking

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There is no accent-free English

Standard Nigerian English is a variety with its own phonology, vocabulary and idiom, spoken by educated Nigerians across the country. It is not a failed attempt at British English, and a production that forces every actor into received pronunciation is making a class and cultural choice whether it admits it or not.

The actor's question is not "is this correct?" but "is this the right variety for this character in this play, and can the audience understand it?"

Intelligibility before authenticity

Some features of Nigerian English carry perfectly and some do not. Vowel length, final consonant clusters and stress placement are the three that decide whether a line reaches the back row. Work on those and leave the rest alone.

The commonest stage faults are equal stress on every syllable, a falling pattern that turns every line into a statement, and swallowed word endings. All three are fixable with drills and a metronome.

Pidgin and code-switching

Nigerian Pidgin is a language with grammar, register and a literature. On stage it can be comic, intimate, threatening or authoritative, depending on the play. Learn the register the character would actually use rather than a generic "stage pidgin" that belongs to no one.

Code-switching - moving between English, pidgin and a Nigerian language within a scene - is one of the most expressive resources a Nigerian actor has. It shows relationship, class and power in a single sentence. Rehearse the switch as a beat, because that is what it is.

Verse, chant and the speaking of the text

Soyinka's verse, Rotimi's rhetorical set pieces and the praise poetry that both draw on need breath, stress and pace. Mark the stresses, find the pauses, and speak the line on the breath rather than at the end of it. Chant and incantation need a lower, more resonant placement than conversational speech.

Record the scene and listen for whether the meaning is clear with your eyes closed. If it is not, the audience is reading the surtitles of your body language instead of hearing the play.

Drills for the specific features

For final consonants, drill minimal pairs and then a paragraph with every final consonant tapped: "he asked for the last list of tests". For stress, take ten sentences and mark the word that carries the new information, then say each sentence three times with the stress in a different place and describe how the meaning changes.

For vowel length, work with pairs such as "sit/seat", "full/fool", "cot/caught" - not to make the actor sound British, but to give the character a choice. A character who cannot distinguish them is a character with fewer options than the actor.

For pace, read a speech at half speed, then at performance speed, then at half speed again. The middle reading is usually the one to keep. Record it and listen with the script in hand, marking every word the listener lost.

The microphone changes the rules

A body microphone rewards intimacy and punishes projection: an actor who belts into a lavalier distorts, and an actor who whispers is heard in the back row. Learn the working distance - about a hand's width from the corner of the mouth - and keep the head turned towards the audience rather than down to the floor.

Rehearse with the microphones on, at performance level, and let the operator ride the levels. A company that only meets its microphones at the dress rehearsal will spend the first performance listening to itself.

Exercises

1. Read the same speech in Standard Nigerian English, in pidgin and in your own language; describe what each version says about the character.
2. Mark the stresses in twenty lines of Soyinka verse and speak them to a partner at the back of the room.
3. Record a scene and transcribe it phonetically; find three features to keep and three to change for clarity.

Where to read more

David Jowitt, Nigerian English Usage (1991)

Peter Roach, English Phonetics and Phonology (any edition)

Cicely Berry, Voice and the Actor (1973)

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